

JKBOSE 2026

CLASS 11TH

SILK ROAD

LECTURE-2

ENGLISH

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Topics To Covered

- 1 ... Lec.02(Silk Road) Detailed explanation (Word to word)
- 2 ... Part 2
- 3 ...
- 4 ...

SILK ROAD



From the gently rolling hills of Ravu, the shortcut took us across vast open plains with nothing in them except a few gazelles that would look up from nibbling (taking small bites) the arid(dry) pastures (land covered with grass) and frown before bounding away into the void. Further on, where the plains became more stony than grassy, a great herd of wild ass came into view. Tsetan told us we were approaching them long before they appeared. “Kyang,” (the wild ass of Tibet), he said, pointing towards a far-off pall of dust. When we drew near, I could see the herd galloping en masse (in a group), wheeling and turning in tight formation as if they were practising manoeuvres(series of movements) on some predetermined course. Plumes (trails) of dust billowed (filled with air) into the crisp, clean air.



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As hills started to push up once more from the rocky wilderness, we passed solitary drokbas ^{alone sphereds} ^{taking care of} tending their flocks. Sometimes men, sometimes women, these well-wrapped figures would pause ^{stop} and stare at our car, occasionally waving as we passed. When the track took us close to their animals, the sheep would take evasive action, (slippery) ^{changing direction} veering away (to change direction suddenly) from the speeding vehicle.

Drokbas: sphereds



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We passed nomads' ^{setup} dark tents pitched in splendid isolation, usually with a huge black dog, a Tibetan ^{dog} mastiff, standing guard. These beasts would ^{raise} cock their great big heads when they became aware of our approach and fix us in their sights. As we continued to draw closer, they would explode into action, speeding directly towards us, like a bullet from a gun and nearly as fast.

Mastiff: dog



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These shaggy (bushy or hairy) ^{frightening} monsters, blacker than the darkest night, usually wore bright red collars and barked furiously with massive jaws. They were completely fearless of our vehicle, shooting straight into our path, causing Tsetan to brake and swerve. (change direction suddenly) The dog would make chase for a hundred metres or so before easing off, (stop chasing) having seen us off the property. It wasn't difficult to understand why ferocious Tibetan mastiffs became popular in China's imperial courts as hunting dogs, brought along the Silk Road in ancient times as ^{gift} tribute from Tibet.



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By now we could see snow-capped mountains gathering on the horizon. We entered a valley where the river was wide and mostly clogged with ice, brilliant white and glinting in the sunshine. The ^{road} trail hugged its bank, ^{Turning, bending} twisting with the ^{Curves, bends} meanders (twists and turns) as we gradually gained height and the valley sides ^{became narrow} closed in.



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The turns became sharper and the ride ^{uneven, rough} bumpier, Tsetan now in third gear as we continued to climb. The track moved away from the icy river, labouring through steeper slopes that sported big rocks daubed (spread a thick sticky substance on a surface carelessly) with patches of bright orange lichen. Beneath the rocks, ^{large pieces} hunks of snow clung on in the near-permanent shade. I felt the pressure building up in my ears, held my nose, snorted and cleared them. We struggled round another tight bend, and Tsetan stopped. He had opened his door and jumped out of his seat before I realised what was going on. "Snow," said Daniel as he too exited the vehicle, letting in a breath of cold air as he did so.



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A swathe (a long strip or area) of the white stuff lay across the track in front of us, stretching for maybe fifteen metres before it petered out (to diminish gradually and stop), and the dirt trail reappeared. The snow continued on either side of us, smoothing the abrupt bank on the upslope side. The bank was too steep for our vehicle to scale (to climb up), so there was no way around the snow patch. I joined Daniel as Tsetan stepped onto the encrusted snow and began to slither (to move smoothly over a surface) and slide forward, stamping his foot from time to time to ascertain how sturdy (hard) it was.



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I looked at my wristwatch. We were at 5,210 metres above sea level. The snow didn't look too deep to me, but the danger wasn't its depth, Daniel said, so much as its icy top layer. "If we slip off, the car could turn over," he suggested, as we saw Tsetan grab handfuls of dirt and fling (throw) them across the frozen surface. We both pitched in and, when the snow was spread with soil, Daniel and I stayed out of the vehicle to lighten Tsetan's load. He backed up and drove towards the dirty snow, eased the car on to its icy surface and slowly drove its length without apparent difficulty.



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Ten minutes later, we stopped at another blockage. “Not good, sir,” Tsetan announced as he jumped out again to survey the scene. This time, he decided to try to drive around the snow.

The slope was steep and studded with major rocks, but somehow Tsetan negotiated them, his four-wheel drive vehicle lurching (moving) from one obstacle to the next. In so doing, he cut off one of the hairpin bends (U-shaped curve), regaining the trail further up where the snow had not drifted.



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I checked my watch again as we continued to climb in the bright sunshine. We crept past 5,400 metres and my head began to throb (pulsate) horribly. I took gulps from my water bottle, which is supposed to help a rapid ascent. (climb on a steep slope)



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We finally reached the top of the pass at 5,515 metres. It was marked by a large cairn of rocks (a pile of stones) festooned (decorated) with white silk scarves and ragged prayer flags. We all took a turn around the cairn (a mound of rough stones) in a clockwise direction as is the tradition, and Tsetan checked the tyres on his vehicle. He stopped at the petrol tank and partially unscrewed the top, which emitted a loud hiss. The lower atmospheric pressure was allowing the fuel to expand. It sounded dangerous to me. "Maybe, sir," Tsetan laughed, "but no smoking."



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My headache soon cleared as we careered down the other side of the pass. It was two o'clock by the time we stopped for lunch. We ate hot noodles inside a long canvas tent, part of a workcamp erected beside a dry salt lake. The ^{high flat land} plateau is pockmarked (disfigured with a scar) with salt flats and brackish (slightly salty water) lakes, vestiges (a trace of something that is disappearing) of the Tethys Ocean which bordered Tibet before the great continental collision that lifted it skyward. This one was a hive of activity, men with pickaxes and shovels trudging back and forth in their long sheepskin coats and salt-encrusted boots. All wore sunglasses against the glare as a steady stream of blue trucks emerged from the blindingly white lake laden with piles of salt.



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By late afternoon, we had reached the small town of Hor, back on the main east-west highway that followed the old trade route from Lhasa to Kashmir. Daniel, who was returning to Lhasa, found a ride in a truck, so Tsetan and I bade him farewell outside a tyre-repair shop. We had suffered two punctures in quick succession on the drive down from the salt lake, and Tsetan was eager to have them fixed since they left him with no spares. Besides, the second tyre he'd changed had been replaced by one that was as smooth as my bald head.



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Hor was a grim, (ugly, grey), miserable place. There was no vegetation whatsoever, just dust and rocks, liberally scattered with years of accumulated (gathered) refuse, which was unfortunate given that the town sat on the shore of Lake Manasarovar, Tibet's most venerated (respected) stretch of water. Ancient Hindu and Buddhist cosmology (science about the origin and development of the universe) pinpoints Manasarovar as the source of four great Indian rivers: the Indus, the Ganges, the Sutlej and the Brahmaputra. Actually, only the Sutlej flows from the lake, but the headwaters of the others all rise nearby on the flanks (sides) of Mount Kailash. We were within striking distance of the great mountain, and I was eager to forge ahead.



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But I had to wait. Tsetan told me to go and drink some tea in Hor's only cafe, which, like all the other buildings in town, was constructed from badly painted concrete and had three broken windows. The good view of the lake through one of them helped to compensate for the draught.



Thank
You